

THE MAN IN THE MIRROR

The personal pictures of one of India's early practitioners of photography provide a rare insight into Amrita Sher-Gil's life



UMRAO SINGH SHER-GIL: HIS MISERY AND HIS MANUSCRIPT

Edited by VIVAN SUNDARAM AND

DEVIKA DAULET-SINGH

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■ By Bandeep Singh

The innocuous family snapshots are like fragments of a personal memory. Viewed from the distance of a few generations, they form a mosaic that reflects a larger picture—of narratives of personal histories and social subtexts. The lavishly produced book of Umrao Singh Sher-Gil's photographs from 1889 to 1949, edited by artist Vivan Sundaram (Umrao Singh's maternal grandson) and Devika Daulet-Singh, heralds an interesting phase in the course of Indian photography where the intimate territory of the family album is being plumbed to unearth social mirrors. The last couple of years have seen a growing interest in photographic archives—both in the public as well as personal spaces. In 2007, *Granta* published the pictures of photographer Dayanita Singh's



IMPRESSIONS OF LIFE: A self-portrait by Umrao Singh (above); Amrita in a swimsuit and a sari

mother Nony Singh. This year, curator Radhika Singh put up a show of her father Swaranjit Singh's photographs.

Umrao Singh, Amrita Sher-Gil's father, belonged to Punjab's wealthy land-owning class. He was a scholar, aesthete and one of the earliest Indian practitioners of photography. The book comprises elaborate and often quirky self portraits and pictures of his (second) Hungarian wife and two daughters—Indira and Amrita. His photographs offer a calm counterpoint to the largely orientalist and ethnographic vision of the early British photogra-